

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 328

By Grills

A RESOLUTION to honor and recognize Holden Farms upon its receipt of the U.S. Poultry & Egg Association's Family Farm Environmental Excellence Award.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that this General Assembly salute that most noble agricultural institution, the family farm, which serves as a cornerstone for our rural communities while providing food and fiber for Tennessee and beyond; and

WHEREAS, one such noteworthy family farm is Holden Farms in Obion County, which, after nomination by the Tennessee Poultry Association, is one of only three farms across the United States selected to receive the U.S. Poultry & Egg Association's (USPOULTRY) Family Farm Environmental Excellence Award; and

WHEREAS, this prestigious award was presented to the Holden family by Bill Griffith, chief operations officer for Peco Foods and USPOULTRY vice chair, during the 2025 International Production and Processing Expo in Atlanta, Georgia; and

WHEREAS, Holden Farms is a fifth-generation, family-operated farm that is managed by Kris and Rebecca Holden along with their sons, Hunter and Hayden; and

WHEREAS, USPOULTRY sponsors the annual awards for exemplary environmental stewardship by family farmers engaged in poultry and egg production; applicants are rated in several categories: nutrient management planning, implementation of novel sustainability practices, community involvement, innovative litter or manure management techniques, and participation in education or outreach programs; and

WHEREAS, in evaluating the farms, a team of environmental professionals from universities, regulatory agencies, and state poultry associations review applications and conduct farm visits; and

WHEREAS, the Holden family manages 2,085 acres of crops and includes Holden Barns Partnership, a six-house poultry operation that was added to the farm in 2022; and

WHEREAS, adding the poultry barns has allowed Holden Farms to reduce its reliance on commercial fertilizers; the litter generated on the farm is used as an organic fertilizer and applied on the acres managed by the Holdens following an extensive and highly effective nutrient management plan; and

WHEREAS, the use of poultry litter has led to substantial improvements in both crop yield and soil health, with micronutrients like copper, sulfur, zinc, and magnesium showing steady increases; Holden Farms applies poultry litter strategically, often before wheat planting, allowing for incorporation into the soil during the sowing process; and

WHEREAS, the Holden family is also dedicated to preserving natural habitats and promoting biodiversity on their farms through the maintenance of several acres of woodlands and buffer zones; these areas serve as vital habitats for native wildlife, ensuring that local species continue to thrive alongside agricultural operations; and

WHEREAS, wildlife plots are carefully planted and maintained to provide a reliable food source for animals during the colder months; in addition, the Holden family manages numerous ponds across their property, which serve dual purposes—controlling runoff and providing a consistent water source for wildlife during dry periods; and

WHEREAS, despite the challenges fence rows can pose to crops, the family has made the intentional decision to preserve them; these areas support mature hardwood trees, which provide essential habitats for wildlife and contribute to environmental health by producing oxygen; and

WHEREAS, Holden Farms currently maintains five Century Farms, which is a program that honors family farmers who have kept continuously owned family land in agricultural production for at least the last 100 years; three more of the farms the Holden family operates will achieve Century Farm status this year; and

WHEREAS, this General Assembly finds it appropriate to acknowledge and applaud the members of the Holden family for their dedication to agriculture, recognizing the importance of the family farm to our rural communities and the State of Tennessee; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Holden Farms for receiving the U.S. Poultry and Egg Association's Family Farm Environmental Excellence Award, applaud their commitment to environmental stewardship and sustainable farming practices, and extend to them our best wishes for every continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.